

Formaldehyde Avoidance Diet



What is it?

People with allergic contact dermatitis can be so sensitive to their allergen that they must avoid skin exposure AND ingestion (eating) of the chemical. This type of allergy could cause dermatitis on the eyelids, hands, face, around the mouth, or at the skin folds (armpits, groin). Some people may have dermatitis all over their bodies.

For some people allergic to formaldehyde, a diet low in formaldehyde can reduce the likelihood of skin reactions. The level of formaldehyde required to produce a response is unknown and can vary from patient to patient. A two-month trial of removing foods and beverages that contain formaldehyde is recommended.

The most common source of formaldehyde in typical diets is the artificial sweetener, aspartame. Aspartame is a low-calorie sweetener that is used in many artificially sweetened food and drink items. After ingestion, aspartame is broken down to the chemicals formic acid and formaldehyde.

It is relatively rare for aspartame to cause allergic contact dermatitis in formaldehyde-sensitive individuals. Affected individuals typically need to consume large amounts of daily aspartame for this to be an issue. However, there have been reports of patients with systemic contact allergy to formaldehyde who have cleared with avoidance of aspartame. Talk to your doctor before proceeding with any specific dietary changes.

Guidelines for Use:

Avoid the following food and beverage items which may contain aspartame. Read labels and look for the word aspartame. Labels may also

include the warning: phenylketonurics: contains phenylalanine.

- Artificial sweeteners, including Equal Original and NutraSweet Original
- Some breakfast cereals
- Reduced-sugar condiments, such as Log Cabin Sugar Free Syrup and Mrs. Butterworth's Sugar Free Syrup
- Cough drops, including Ricola Sugar Free and Halls Sugar Free
- Beverages
- Diet drink mixes, including Crystal Light and Wyler's Light
- Zero-sugar or diet sodas, including Diet Coke, Coke Zero, Diet Pepsi, Pepsi Zero, Diet Snapple, Fanta Zero, Sprite Zero
- Diet sweets, desserts, and snacks
- Sugar-free gelatin, including Sugar-free Jell-O and Sugar-free Royal Gelatin
- Sugar-free gum, including Trident, Extra, Wrigley's and Mentos
- Prepackaged fruits
- Prepackaged foods, including Winsor Bay Coconut Breaded Shrimp
- Protein bars, powders, and shakes
- Sugar-free candy, drinks, syrups, ice cream
- Yogurt, including Muller light
- Chewable vitamins and medications
- Supplements
- Fiber supplements

You can check the EWG's Food Scores website for a more complete listing of foods that contain aspartame: www.ewg.org/foodscores. Type "aspartame" into the search bar, then check the box "Ingredients", then click on "Products with aspartame".

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There are also some foods that naturally contain small amounts of formaldehyde.

These include smoked ham, sausages, other meats, fish (deep frozen hake, cod), tomatoes, bananas, potatoes, cauliflower, kohlrabi, beets, other fruits/vegetables, coffee, syrup, caviar, mushrooms and milk. Formaldehyde may also be present on produce if it is treated.

References:

1. *Contact Dermatitis* 2012;67:315-6.
2. *Contact Dermatitis* 2003;49:258-9.
3. *EFSA Journal* 2014;12(2):3550.

In addition, the ACDS Contact Allergen Management Program® (CAMP®) can help manage contact dermatitis. It helps to find products that are safe to use by creating a list of products that do not contain one's allergens. For more information about CAMP®, please ask your doctor or visit www.contactderm.org.

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